

2. The following excerpt is from Jeannette Haien’s novel *The All of It*, published in 1986. In this passage, Father Declan, an Irish priest, is driving home after a successful fishing trip. Read the passage carefully. Then, in a well-written essay, analyze how Haien uses literary elements and techniques to develop a complex portrayal of Father Declan.

In your response you should do the following:

- Respond to the prompt with a thesis that presents a defensible interpretation.
- Select and use evidence to support your line of reasoning.
- Explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning.
- Use appropriate grammar and punctuation in communicating your argument.

Par.

- 1 Nothing exaggerates a sense of lonely solitude so much as a long night drive through thrashing rain and dense, culpfit fog.
- 2 Crouched over the steering-wheel of the old Ford, his head thrust forward, turtle-like, out of his collar, the only sound the sidelong loping strokes of the windshield wipers, he peered ahead through the car lights’ gauzy beam at the narrow, winding road which kept vanishing and reappearing like a dark ribbon in a magician’s hand, seen now, now not, depending on the shift of the fog....
- 3 It was terrible the way his splendid excitement had vanished almost the instant he’d left the Castle and started the homeward journey, the lilt and thrill of his great adventure draining from him suddenly, to be as suddenly replaced by a violent flush of self-pity caused (admit it) by the sorrowful fact that at the end of the long night drive there would be nought for him but the bulk emptiness of the bleak parish-house, its outside walls bleeding with damp, its windows dark, its high, cold rooms devoid of life except as he would enter them only to encounter, going before him in the chilly chambers, the exhaled, ghostly haze of his own breath; that...deadliness, juxtaposed to the powerful vividness of its imagined opposite: anticipation—of a lit window, of a waiting presence, of a voice asking those simple, linking, engaging questions which absence inspires: “How are you?” “How did you fare?” “What was it like?”
- 4 Oh, the blanknesses of solitude....
- 5 He ought to get a dog, a lively, sensitive puppy he could rear to companionable habits; one that would accompany him on walks and ride beside him in the car, that would sleep next to his bed and wag him awake of a morning, a warm, affectionate, entertaining little dog. He pictured the creature: a smallish terrier, a brindled,¹ charming cairn or smoothcoated brown-and-white Jack Russell,² all spiff and prance and independence but ready ever for a petting. “Father Declan’s little dog,” mothers would say of it in a recommending way, meaning it wouldn’t snap when their children stooped to pat it. “Tis Father Declan’s”: assurance that it wouldn’t forget itself and spot the carpet.... Was there anything written against a priest having a dog? For sure the Bishop didn’t have one. Could he think of a sixtyish priest he knew who did? He couldn’t; though Father Patrick Joyce in Galway kept a toothless, stiff, off-putting thing of a cat, a feature of parish-house life you’d be less surprised by in Galway than in Roonatellin, priests in Galway being laws unto themselves.... And of course, there was the obstacle of Mrs. Duggin, who “did” for him as hasty morning-cleaner and washer and (hastier) cook. (He’d try again hinting to her how much he’d appreciate a bit of noontime meat or fish not fried to the consistency of cement, or a veg not boiled to a rag’s limpness.) Mrs. Duggin wouldn’t take to a dog.... He could hear

her: “I’m hoovering³ *hairs*, Father, *dog* hairs,” tousling the thin of her own, her mouth dropped disapprovingly. “It’s not that I’m complaining of the work, the amount of it, but *dog* hairs—”

6 But must he forever give in to the Mrs. Duggins of the world? forever keep sublimating wishes? as he was this instant sublimating (*burying*, or trying to) the wish (he struck the word *desire*) to share with someone this singular-in-his-life, brilliantly prodigious, gallimaufry⁴ twenty-four-pound-ten-ounce day, the bodily fact of it residing in the car’s boot,⁵ causing now that worrisome, unhealthy, grinding sound the engine was making (or so, in his angler’s⁶ pride, he fancied the source of the noise to be)....

7 Innocent, the mere wishing of a mere wish.

From *The All of It* by Jeannette Haien. Copyright © 1986 by Jeannette Haien. Used by permission of HarperCollins Publishers.

1: brownish or tawny, with streaks of color

2: Cairn and Jack Russell are both breeds of terrier.

3: vacuuming

4: chaotic

5: trunk

6: fisher’s